The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Getty Images

America's main oil benchmark rose to its highest level since mid-2022 on Thursday after Donald Trump warned in a televised address that he would hit Iran "extremely hard". **Iran** responded defiantly to Mr Trump's claim that America was close to meeting its military objectives. A senior Iranian general said "no one should survive" if America launched a ground offensive and vowed that Iran would "not rest until we achieve our goals".

Mr Trump unveiled **tariffs** of up to 100% on some branded drugs, targeting **pharmaceutical companies** that have not lowered prices or increased manufacturing in America. Generic medicines will be exempt. At the same time, his administration eased tariffs on products that contain small amounts of steel, aluminium or copper, and simplified how those duties are calculated.

Mr Trump sacked **Pam Bondi**, the attorney-general. Over the past 14 months, Ms Bondi has overseen the **Department of Justice's** failed attempts to prosecute the president's enemies. Mr Trump was also reportedly displeased with her handling of the Epstein files. Calling her a "loyal friend", Mr Trump said that Todd Blanche, her deputy, would serve as acting attorney-general.

The **Philippines** said **Iran** had granted “safe, unhindered and expeditious” passage for its vessels through the **Strait of Hormuz**. The South-East Asian country, which gets the majority of its energy supplies from the Middle East, said the move would allow “steady delivery” of oil and fertiliser. Separately, Britain is convening around 30 countries for talks on Thursday to co-ordinate diplomatic efforts to reopen the strait.

Blue Owl enforced a cap on redemptions, at 5% of shares per quarter, from two of its private-credit funds following a surge in requests for withdrawals. In the first quarter investors asked to withdraw 21.9% of shares from its $36bn private-credit fund and 40.7% from a smaller technology-focused fund, up from 5.2% and 15.7% in the previous quarter, respectively. The decision will add to fears about a developing private-credit crisis.

Tesla delivered 358,000 vehicles globally in the first quarter of 2026, a rise of 6% on the same period the year before, but below analysts’ expectations. The electric-vehicle maker is grappling with slowing demand and rising competition, particularly from Chinese firms. The company’s boss, Elon Musk, wants to refocus on robotaxis and robotics. Shares in Tesla fell by around 4% on the delivery news.

America’s secretary of state, Marco Rubio, said China’s detention of ships flying Panama’s flag threatened the Caribbean country’s sovereignty. China denies claims that it is detaining or delaying vessels in retaliation for a Panamanian court ruling in January that stripped two ports on the Panama Canal from CK Hutchinson, a Hong-Kong conglomerate. Mr Trump wants to limit China’s influence over the canal.

Figure of the day: 600-800, the typical calorie count of a sticky toffee pudding with custard. Read about why the British favourite is back in vogue.

Photograph: AFP via Getty Images

Trump demands more from America's allies

No country has joined America in battle in Iran apart from Israel, which led the charge. Mr Trump has been scathing about European leaders. In a speech on Wednesday, he called on them to "build up some delayed courage" to secure safe shipping in the Strait of Hormuz. The economic fallout from its closure is now forcing America's allies to act—albeit not how Mr Trump would like.

On Thursday Britain will convene a group of 35 foreign ministers to try to find a way to reopen the Strait of Hormuz after the fighting stops. Mr Trump has suggested he could end the war without a deal to protect the strait, panicking governments reliant on oil and gas from the Gulf. Britain's initiative has been likened to the "coalition of the willing", intended to support Ukraine after a ceasefire. It includes the G7 countries (with the unsurprising exception of America), lots of European ones and some Gulf states, such as Bahrain. "Coalition of the weary" might be more accurate.

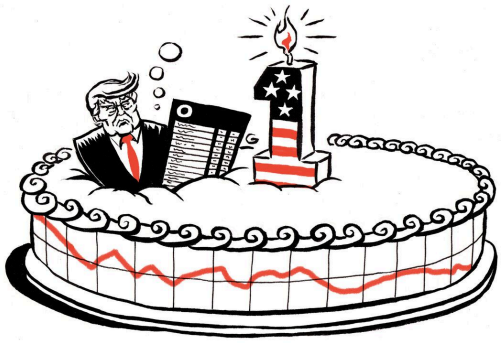


Illustration: David Simons

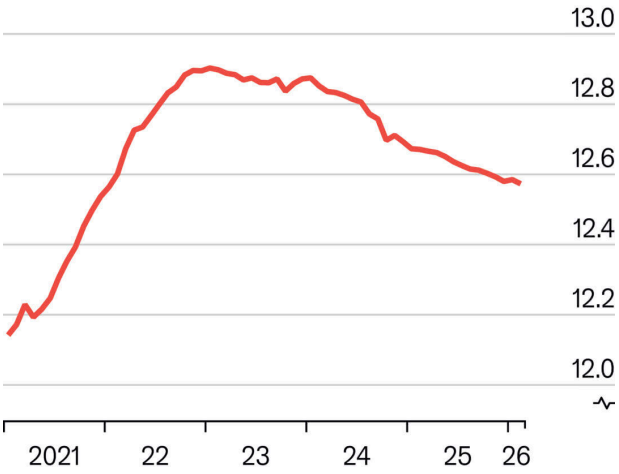
America’s one-eyed merchants

American manufacturers should have done well out of the global trade war Donald Trump unleashed on “Liberation Day” a year ago on Thursday. But even they are at best lukewarm on Mr Trump’s tariffs, which raised levies to the highest level in nearly a century.

Manufacturers bemoan the uncertainty of yo-yoing tariff rates, and the mountain of paperwork that comes with remaining compliant. The sector has shed 100,000 jobs since Mr Trump took office; the rest of the economy has put on 300,000. Another problem is tariffs on inputs, such as raw materials or machines. Many of these are imported, forcing manufacturers to swallow the levy or pass on the costs to customers. Some of the tariffs expire in July. And the next presidential election is not far off; if a Democrat (or a less tariff-prone Republican) succeeds Mr Trump, they could pare the levies back. Pity any manager planning for recruitment or investment.

Spanner in the works

United States, manufacturing employment, m



Source: Bureau of Labour Statistics

Photograph: Getty Images

Britain’s embattled broadcaster

Tim Davie, the BBC’s outgoing director-general, no doubt hoped for a quiet end to his tenure. Instead, as he departs on Thursday a new scandal has struck the broadcaster. The BBC abruptly sacked Scott Mills, a radio star, reportedly because of allegations that he had a relationship with an underage teenage boy more than 25 years ago. Looming larger still is the issue that forced Mr Davie’s exit: a deceptively edited documentary, which later triggered Donald Trump’s $10bn lawsuit.

Mr Davie’s replacement, Matt Brittin, a former executive at Google, will have to deal with longer-standing challenges. In a polarised world he must keep an audience for a broadcaster with a policy of impartiality. Streaming giants such as Netflix make the BBC’s mandate to appeal to the tastes of an entire nation look antiquated. Mr Brittin is also tasked with protecting the BBC’s voice abroad, where it remains one of the few trusted news sources. Quite the in-tray.

Photograph: Getty Images

A second helping of Wegovy

GLP-1 drugs were originally sold as diabetes medications and have since marched on to become weight-loss drugs. Now Britain's health service will prescribe semaglutide—sold as Wegovy—for cardiovascular prevention. This week NHS England, part of Britain's health service, announced a deal with Novo Nordisk, the drug's Danish manufacturer, to make semaglutide available to 1.2m people who have already suffered a heart attack or stroke.

The case for this is strong. A 2023 study of semaglutide's effectiveness found a 20% relative reduction in major cardiovascular events, with an absolute risk reduction of 1.5%. These benefits appeared before significant weight loss occurred, leading researchers to believe the effect comes from the drug acting directly on the heart and blood vessels, rather than through shedding the kilos.

Wegovy might also be useful for the millions more Britons with cardiovascular disease. Yet, as patients with obesity have already found, a drug can be effective yet unaffordable for the NHS. Expect a slow roll-out.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Thursday: Which Admiral was selected to be commander of the US Pacific fleet in the wake of the Pearl Harbour attacks?

Wednesday: Who was the only American president to be born in Missouri?

One forges one’s style on the terrible anvil of daily deadlines.

Émile Zola